
IF YOU DON'T KNOW, ASK.

How to turn brain dumps into structured briefs using Claude's interview process.

CONTEXT ENGINEERING FROM CHAOS TO CLARITY

Voice to text. Brain dump to brief. Half-baked to fully structured.
Stop trying to write the perfect prompt. Start a conversation instead.

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Henry Nicholson

[linkedin.com/in/henrymnicholson](https://www.linkedin.com/in/henrymnicholson)

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THE PROBLEM WITH PROMPTING

Everyone is obsessed with writing the perfect prompt. The internet is full of prompt templates, prompt libraries, prompt engineering courses. And most of it misses the point entirely.

Here's the truth: if you already knew exactly what you wanted, you wouldn't need AI to help you figure it out. The whole reason you're talking to Claude is because your idea is half-formed. You've got pieces of the vision but not the whole picture. You know the vibe but not the specifics. You've got energy but not structure.

The best prompt isn't a prompt at all. It's a conversation.

When you try to cram a half-baked idea into a single prompt, you leave out the details you haven't thought about yet. And Claude fills those gaps with assumptions. Sometimes they're right. Usually they're generic. The output feels close but not quite right, so you re-prompt, tweak, re-prompt again. You're debugging your own vagueness.

The fix: don't write a better prompt. Let Claude interview you instead. When Claude doesn't know something, it should ask. And when you don't know something, talking through it with structured questions will help you figure it out. That's the workflow this guide is built around.

VOICE TO TEXT: THE BEST FIRST STEP

Before you type a single word into Claude, talk. Open your phone, hit the mic icon in the Claude app, and just start going. Brain dump. Stream of consciousness. Don't edit yourself. Don't worry about structure. Just get the idea out of your head and into text.

Most people think faster than they type. Your voice captures nuance, energy, and connections that get lost when you try to organize your thoughts into a written prompt.

WHY VOICE-FIRST WORKS

- **Speed:** You can speak 150 words per minute. You type maybe 50. Voice gets 3x more raw material into the conversation.
- **Authenticity:** When you talk, you explain things the way you actually think about them. No filtering, no over-structuring.
- **Association:** Speaking out loud triggers connections. You'll mention things you wouldn't have thought to type.
- **Low friction:** There's no blank page anxiety. You're just talking.

THE FLOW

Step 1: Open Claude. Hit the mic. Talk for 60-90 seconds about your idea, project, or problem. Don't stop to think. Just go.

Step 2: Claude now has your raw brain dump as text. It's messy. That's the point.

Step 3: Ask Claude to interview you. This is where the magic happens. Claude reads your dump, identifies the gaps, and starts asking targeted questions to fill them in.

Step 4: Answer the questions (voice or text). Each round adds clarity and structure.

Step 5: After 3-5 rounds, Claude compiles everything into a structured brief, spec, or action plan.

You went from a messy voice note to a structured deliverable without ever writing a 'prompt.' You just had a conversation.

THE INTERVIEW METHOD

The interview method flips the traditional prompting dynamic. Instead of you telling Claude what to do, Claude tells you what it needs to know. You become the subject matter expert. Claude becomes the interviewer extracting your expertise.

HOW IT WORKS

You give Claude your raw input, whatever it looks like. A voice dump. Bullet points. A half-finished thought. A screenshot. Then you tell Claude to interview you, in batches of 5-10 questions at a time, to fill in the gaps and build toward a specific output.

The key is increments. Not 30 questions at once. 5-10 per round. This keeps the conversation focused and lets your answers in one round inform the questions in the next.

WHY 5-10 QUESTIONS PER ROUND

- **Cognitive load:** More than 10 questions at once feels like a form. 5-10 feels like a conversation.
- **Progressive depth:** Round 1 covers the big picture. Round 2 digs into specifics. Round 3 refines edge cases. Each round goes deeper.
- **Context building:** Your answers in Round 1 give Claude context to ask smarter questions in Round 2. The interview gets sharper as it goes.
- **Natural stopping point:** After 3-5 rounds (15-50 questions total), you've covered everything. Claude has enough to build.

WHAT CLAUDE IS ACTUALLY DOING

When you tell Claude to interview you, it's doing context engineering in real time. It reads your input, identifies what's clear and what's ambiguous, maps out the gaps, and generates questions designed to fill those gaps systematically. Each answer you give adds to the context window. By the end of the interview, Claude has a rich, detailed understanding of your vision, not because you wrote a perfect prompt, but because you answered honest questions.

STACKED INTERVIEWS: CREATIVE THEN TECHNICAL

For complex projects, one interview isn't enough. You need stacked interviews, where each layer covers a different dimension of the work. The creative interview and the technical interview ask fundamentally different questions, and separating them produces better results than trying to do both at once.

LAYER 1: THE CREATIVE INTERVIEW

This covers the what and the why. What are you building? What should it feel like? Who is it for? What's the vibe? What's the story? What existing things does it remind you of? This is about vision, direction, and intent. No implementation details yet.

- What's the core idea in one sentence?
- Who is this for and what problem does it solve?
- What should it feel like to the end user?
- What existing products or content capture the vibe you want?
- What would success look like?

LAYER 2: THE TECHNICAL INTERVIEW

This covers the how. Now that the creative direction is locked, what are the specifics? Tech stack, platforms, formats, constraints, deliverables. This is about turning vision into spec.

- What platform or format does this need to ship on?
- What are the hard constraints? (budget, timeline, tools)
- What's the tech stack or toolchain?
- What does the file structure or deliverable format look like?
- What are the non-negotiable requirements?

WHY STACKING WORKS

If you mix creative and technical questions in the same interview, people default to answering the easy ones (the technical specs) and gloss over the hard ones (the creative vision). By separating them, you force depth on both. The creative interview ensures the vision is clear before implementation starts. The technical interview ensures the spec is airtight before building starts.

Vision first, then spec. Always in that order. If you spec before the vision is clear, you build the wrong thing efficiently.

BRAIN DUMP TO BRIEF IN 5 ROUNDS

Here's the complete workflow from chaotic idea to polished deliverable. Five rounds, each building on the last.

ROUND 1: THE DUMP

Speak or type your raw idea. Don't organize it. Don't edit it. Just get everything out. This is your starting material. It can be 30 seconds of voice or 3 paragraphs of scattered thoughts. Tell Claude: 'Here's my brain dump. Interview me to turn this into a structured brief. Ask 5-10 questions at a time.'

ROUND 2: THE BIG PICTURE

Claude asks its first batch of questions: the broad strokes. Who is this for? What's the goal? What does success look like? What's the scope? These questions clarify the shape of the project before diving into details. Answer quickly and honestly. If you don't know, say so.

ROUND 3: THE DETAILS

Now Claude goes deeper. Based on your Round 2 answers, it asks about specifics: tone, format, audience nuance, technical requirements, content structure, references. This is where vague ideas become concrete decisions. You'll start seeing the brief take shape.

ROUND 4: THE EDGE CASES

Claude pressure-tests the brief. What about this scenario? How should it handle that? What if the audience interprets it differently? This round catches the things you didn't think about. It's where good briefs become great ones.

ROUND 5: THE COMPILE

Claude takes everything from Rounds 1-4 and assembles it into a structured document: a creative brief, a product spec, a campaign strategy, a technical PRD, whatever the project needs. You review, adjust, and finalize. Done.

Five rounds. Maybe 15 minutes total. You went from 'I have this idea...' to a document you can hand to a team, a client, or another AI agent and they'll know exactly what to build.

COPY-PASTE PROMPT: THE CREATIVE INTERVIEW

Use this when you have a creative idea, campaign concept, content strategy, or brand project that needs structure. Send your brain dump first, then this prompt.

PROMPT

```
I just gave you a brain dump of an idea. Your job is to interview me to turn this into a structured creative brief. Do NOT try to build anything yet. Interview me in rounds of 5-10 questions. Start with the big picture (vision, audience, goals) and progressively get more specific (tone, format, style, references, constraints) with each round. Rules: - Ask 5-10 questions per round, never more - Wait for my answers before asking the next round - If my answer is vague, ask a follow-up to sharpen it - If I say 'I don't know,' suggest 2-3 options I can pick from instead - After 3-5 rounds, compile everything into a structured creative brief with these sections: - Project Overview - Target Audience - Creative Direction & Tone - Key Messages - Deliverables & Formats - References & Inspiration - Constraints & Requirements - Success Metrics Start Round 1 now.
```

COPY-PASTE PROMPT: THE TECHNICAL INTERVIEW

Use this when you're building software, a tool, an app, or any technical project. Works great after a creative interview to add the implementation layer.

PROMPT

```
I just gave you a brain dump of something I want to build. Your job is to interview me to turn this into a complete technical spec. Do NOT start building yet. Interview me in rounds of 5-10 questions. Start broad (what is this, who uses it, what does it do) and get progressively more specific (tech stack, data model, UI/UX, edge cases, deployment) with each round. Rules: - Ask 5-10 questions per round, never more - Wait for my answers before the next round - If I say 'I don't know' or 'you decide,' make a recommendation and explain why - Challenge assumptions that might cause problems later - After 3-5 rounds, compile into a technical spec: - Project Overview & Goals - User Stories / Use Cases - Tech Stack & Architecture - Data Model / Schema - UI/UX Requirements - API / Integration Points - File Structure - Deployment & Infrastructure - Edge Cases & Error Handling - MVP Scope vs Future Features Start Round 1 now.
```

COPY-PASTE PROMPT: THE BRAND & COPY INTERVIEW

Use this when you need copy, messaging, or brand work but don't have a clear brief yet. Perfect for freelancers, agencies, and personal brands.

PROMPT

```
I need help with copy / messaging / brand work but my brief is half-baked. Interview me to build a complete brief before writing anything. Interview me in rounds of 5-10 questions. Cover: - Round 1: Who is the brand and who are they talking to - Round 2: Voice, tone, and personality - Round 3: Specific deliverables and channels - Round 4: Examples of what good looks like (and what to avoid) - Round 5: Compile into a copy brief Rules: - 5-10 questions per round, never more - Wait for my answers before the next round - If I give you a vague answer like 'professional but friendly,' push me to be more specific with examples - If I don't know, give me 2-3 options to react to - After all rounds, compile into a copy brief with: - Brand Snapshot - Audience Profile - Voice & Tone Guide - Key Messages (primary + supporting) - Channel-Specific Notes - Do Say / Don't Say - Example Copy (2-3 samples in the defined voice) Start Round 1 now.
```

COPY-PASTE PROMPT: THE PRODUCT / FEATURE INTERVIEW

Use this when you're scoping a new feature, product idea, or MVP. Great for founders, PMs, and anyone who has the vision but not the spec.

PROMPT

```
I have a product / feature idea that I need to scope out. Interview me to turn my rough concept into a structured product brief. Do NOT start building or designing yet. Interview me in rounds of 5-10 questions: - Round 1: The problem and the user - Round 2: The solution and core experience - Round 3: Scope, constraints, and priorities - Round 4: Edge cases, risks, and unknowns - Round 5: Compile the brief Rules: - 5-10 questions per round, never more - Wait for my answers before the next round - Push back if scope seems too large for the stated timeline or resources - If I say 'I don't know,' help me think through it with options or frameworks - After all rounds, compile into a product brief: - Problem Statement - Target User - Proposed Solution - Core User Flow - MVP Feature Set (must-have vs nice-to-have) - Technical Considerations - Open Questions / Risks - Success Metrics - Next Steps Start Round 1 now.
```

COPY-PASTE PROMPT: THE UNIVERSAL BRAIN DUMP PROCESSOR

The catch-all. When you don't know what category your idea falls into, or it spans multiple categories, use this. Claude will figure out what kind of interview you need based on your dump.

PROMPT

```
Here's a brain dump. It's messy and half-formed. That's intentional. Your job: 1. Read the dump and identify what I'm trying to do 2. Categorize it (creative project, technical build, brand/copy work, product idea, strategy, or hybrid) 3. Tell me what you understood and what's still unclear 4. Then interview me in rounds of 5-10 questions to fill in the gaps Rules: - Start by reflecting back what you understood in 2-3 sentences so I can correct anything off-base - Ask 5-10 questions per round, never more - Wait for my answers before the next round - Adapt your questions based on the category -- if it's creative, ask about vision and audience. If it's technical, ask about stack and architecture. If it's both, stack the interviews (creative first, then technical) - If I say 'I don't know,' give me options to react to - After 3-5 rounds, compile into the appropriate structured document (brief, spec, strategy, etc.) - Ask me to confirm the output format before compiling [PASTE YOUR BRAIN DUMP BELOW]
```

BUILDING ON THE BRIEF: WHAT COMES NEXT

The brief is the starting point, not the finish line. Once Claude has interviewed you and compiled a structured document, that document becomes your context file. It's reusable, shareable, and it makes every conversation after it dramatically better.

USE THE BRIEF AS CONTEXT

Drop the compiled brief into a Claude Project as persistent context. Now every conversation within that project starts with full understanding. Ask for social copy, it knows the audience and tone. Ask for a landing page, it knows the product and positioning. Ask for code, it knows the stack and architecture. The brief is your single source of truth.

HAND IT TO AGENT TEAMS

If you're using Claude Code with agent teams, the brief becomes the starting context for every agent. Put it in your CLAUDE.md. When the lead agent spawns teammates, they all inherit the same understanding. The frontend agent knows the design direction. The backend agent knows the data model. The test agent knows the user stories. Consistency from day one because the brief was thorough.

SHARE IT WITH HUMANS

The brief works just as well for human collaborators. Send it to your team, your client, your freelancer. Everyone is aligned on the same vision because it was built through a real interview process, not a quick Slack message.

ITERATE ON IT

Briefs evolve. After the first sprint, after user feedback, after a pivot, go back to Claude with the existing brief and say 'interview me again to update this.' Claude reads the current version, asks what's changed, and produces an updated document. The brief stays alive.

The interview produced the brief. The brief produces the work. The work produces the feedback. The feedback updates the brief. That's the loop.

STOP PROMPTING. START TALKING.

The entire premise of prompt engineering assumes you already know what you want. But the most interesting work starts before you know what you want. It starts with a feeling, a hunch, a fragment of an idea that doesn't have shape yet.

That's not a problem to solve. That's the starting condition for everything creative, technical, and strategic. The question is how you get from fragment to form.

The answer is embarrassingly simple: talk about it. Let someone ask you questions. Answer honestly. Say 'I don't know' when you don't know. Watch the shape emerge.

THE TOOLKIT

- **Voice to text** for the raw dump
- **Stacked interviews** (creative then technical) for structured depth
- **5-10 questions per round** for manageable progression
- **3-5 rounds** to go from chaos to clarity
- **Compiled briefs** as reusable context files
- **Projects and CLAUDE.md** to make the brief persistent
- **Agent teams** to scale the brief into parallel execution

You don't need a better prompt. You need a better conversation. And the best conversations start with one thing: if you don't know, ask.

The best ideas don't arrive fully formed. They arrive as fragments. The interview process is how fragments become blueprints.

If you made it this far, comment **"ask"** on the post. I want to know who actually reads these.

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Henry Nicholson

Junior Associate, Global Prairie · Co-Founder, ForeFront USD

[linkedin.com/in/henrymnicholson](https://www.linkedin.com/in/henrymnicholson)